8-WEEK PLAN

Upper / Lower

8 weeks, 4 days.

Days 4 a week **Session** 45–60 min **Equipment** Full gym
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What this is

An upper/lower split trains the whole body with two kinds of session. Upper days cover chest, back, shoulders and arms. Lower days cover quads, hamstrings, glutes and calves. You run two of each every week, so each muscle is worked about twice in seven days. That is the frequency that returns the most growth for the least recovery cost at this stage of training. A muscle recovers from a hard session in about two to three days, and training it again at that point keeps the growth signal up without stacking fatigue. The two upper days are not copies of each other. One leads with chest, the other leads with back, and both finish with the same shoulder and arm work. The two lower days differ in the lead movement and the hamstring movement. The eight weeks do one thing. Weeks one to four teach you the movements and add a rep each week at a fixed load. Weeks five to eight add load against a rep range. Week eight ends with a re-test of week one's loads, so you leave with a number, not a feeling. I have run this split myself and with clients for years. The lifts, the tempos and the intensity techniques are the ones I use.

Who it's for

- Zero to two years of consistent training, or anyone coming back after time off.
- Four days a week available, most weeks.
- A commercial gym with barbells, dumbbells, cables and the usual machines.
- Someone who wants balanced upper and lower body development from sessions of 45 to 60 minutes.

Who it's not for

- Anyone who can only train three days a week. Four is the structure. Three days breaks the pairing.
- Advanced lifters who need higher frequency or a specialization block.
- Anyone with a current lower back injury. The hinge movements are part of the plan.

Equipment: full gym. Barbell and rack, adjustable bench, dumbbells, a cable stack, a lat pulldown, a row machine or chest-supported row, a hack squat or leg press, a leg curl machine, a calf raise station. Substitutions are listed under every session.

Before you start

The five rules

1. The plan is decided before the week starts. You do not choose exercises, sets or loads in the gym. You read the table and do it.
2. Bodyweight is a weekly average, never a single weigh-in. Your weight swings two to five pounds a day from water and food. One number is noise. Use the weekly average.
3. A missed day is data, not failure. It tells you what in the plan doesn't fit your life yet.
4. Log every session. Exercise, load, reps per set, how many reps were left. The plan works off the record. A session that isn't logged didn't happen as far as progression is concerned.
5. Progress is checked against the record, not against how you feel. Feelings are weather. The log is climate.

Finding your starting loads

There are no fixed weights in this document. Week one, session one of each day type is a load-finding session. For every exercise, work up in small jumps until you find a load you can lift for the bottom of the rep range, eight reps, with two reps left in you. That is your starting load. Write it down. If you get eight easily and could have done twelve, the load is too light. Add weight and do the set again. If you get six and the seventh would have failed, it is too heavy. Take weight off. Two or three tries per exercise is normal in week one. That is the point of the week.

Three exercises work differently. The triceps drop set starts with a close-grip load you can press for eight to twelve. Calves start at body weight or a light load that lets you reach fifteen full reps. Biceps run six short-rest sets, so pick a load you can curl for ten on the first set with two left. Reps will fall across the six sets. That is expected.

Load-finding is the whole of week one. It is not a wasted week. It is the baseline for the re-test in week eight.

The warm-up

Five to ten minutes, the same every session.

- Three minutes easy on a bike, rower or treadmill walk. Enough to raise your temperature, not enough to tire you.
- Upper days: ten band pull-aparts, ten arm circles each direction, ten push-ups.
- Lower days: ten bodyweight squats, ten hip hinges with hands on hips, ten walking lunges each leg, ten bodyweight calf raises.
- First exercise of the session: two ramp sets. Half the working load for eight reps, then three quarters of the working load for five. Then start the working sets.
- Every exercise after that: one ramp set at about two thirds of the working load for five reps.

If something hurts in a way that isn't muscle fatigue, stop and see a professional. This plan is not medical advice.

The eight weeks

WEEK	WHAT CHANGES	LOAD RULE	NOTES
1	Load-finding. Every lift at the bottom of its range: eight reps, calves fifteen.	Find a load you can lift for eight with two reps left. Record it for every exercise.	Read the whole week before day one. Expect two or three tries per lift.
2	Nine reps per set.	Same load as week 1.	If nine is not there on a set, write down what was. Same load next week.
3	Ten reps per set.	Same load as week 1.	Sessions start to feel heavy at the end. Rest periods are not optional.
4	Eleven reps per set.	Same load as week 1.	Four weeks of three-question answers. Check the gate on the compliance page.
5	Double progression begins. Work in the 8 to 12 range.	When every set of an exercise hits twelve with one rep left, add 5 to 10 lb on big lifts, 2.5 to 5 lb on small ones, and drop back to eight.	Most lifts move up this week or next. Some move up twice before week 8.
6	Double progression.	Same rule.	A lift that hasn't moved in two weeks goes to the stalled-lift rule.
7	Double progression.	Same rule.	Last full week. Record the working load on every exercise.
8	Re-test. Every session this week runs week 1's loads.	Week 1 loads, same sets. Each set goes to the plan's reps in reserve. Write the reps down.	The difference between these reps and week 1's eight is your number. Write the week 7 working load beside it.

How progression works

Weeks one to four are linear. The load does not change. You add one rep to every set each week, so eight becomes nine, then ten, then eleven. This teaches the movements with a load you can control, builds work capacity, and gets the tempo into your hands before the weights go up. If a set falls short of the week's rep target, log what you got and keep the load. Do not add weight in weeks one to four.

Weeks five to eight are double progression. Every exercise works in a range of eight to twelve reps. You hold the load and push reps up across sessions. When every set of an exercise reaches twelve with one rep still in reserve, add weight at the next session, 5 to 10 lb on the big lifts (presses, pulldowns, rows, squats, hinges) and 2.5 to 5 lb on the small ones (raises, curls, triceps, calves), and start again at eight. Two things have to be true before load goes up: every set, not just the first, and one rep in reserve, not a grinder. The log tells you when. Your mood does not.

Reps in reserve in this plan: two in weeks one to four, one in weeks five to eight, on the big lifts. Machine, dumbbell and isolation work may go to failure on the last set of an exercise from week five on. No working set is ever more than three reps from failure. Most people underestimate their strength and stop early. The rep target and the reserve rule exist to stop that.

Week eight is the re-test. Each day type runs once that week, so all four sessions are re-tests. Load the bar with week one's starting load for every exercise, run the same number of sets, and on each set stop at the plan's reps in reserve. Write down the reps. Eight weeks ago that load gave you eight reps with two left. The reps you get now, next to that eight, is what the plan did. Write the week seven working load beside it.

Deload triggers

Any one of these fires a deload: performance on a key lift drops two sessions in a row, five days of feeling flat and heavy, or a week of bad sleep. Deload the same week you notice. Half the sets, 80 to 90 percent of the load, three to four reps in reserve on every set, nothing to failure. Then resume the plan where you left it. A deload is not a lost week. It is the reason the next three weeks go up.

The sessions

Tempo is written as four numbers. 3-0-1-0 means three seconds lowering, no pause at the bottom, one second lifting, no pause at the top. 3-1-1-0 means three seconds lowering, a one-second pause at the bottom or the stretch, one second up, no pause at the top. The three-second lowering is on every pressing and pulling movement in this plan, every rep. Count it. The lift is fast and controlled, never thrown. The intensity techniques are explained in the Notes column the first time each one appears and named after that.

Day 1: Upper A (chest focus)

Chest leads. Incline press is the main lift of the day. Shoulders and arms close every upper session.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Incline press, barbell or dumbbell	4	8–12	3-0-1-0	2–3 min	Bench at 30 to 45 degrees. Elbows tucked, bar to the upper chest, dumbbells with elbows at 45 degrees. Three seconds down, press hard. Spotter or safety bars on the barbell.
Flat dumbbell press or machine chest press	3	8–12	3-0-1-0	2 min	Same tempo as the incline. Squeeze the chest at the top. Control down, fast up.
Front delt press, dumbbell or machine	3	8–12	3-0-1-0	2 min	Elbows tucked in, not flared. Press straight up, not forward. Stop just short of lockout to keep tension on.
Lateral raise, dumbbell	3	8–12	3-0-1-0	90 sec	Straight sets, no techniques. Lead with the elbows, not the hands. Shoulder height and no higher. Three seconds down.
Rear delt punch out, cable or machine	3	8–12	3-1-1-0	90 sec	Pull away from the body and turn the hands in at the peak. Stop before the traps take over. One-second pause at the stretch, then pull fast.
Triceps mechanical drop set, close grip to wide grip	3	To failure	3-0-1-0	2 min	Mechanical drop set: start with the hard version of the movement, close-grip bar press, to failure. Without resting, widen the grip, which makes the leverage easier, and go to failure again. That is one set.
Biceps, one exercise, short rest	6	8–12	3-0-1-0	30–45 sec	Pick one: barbell curl, dumbbell curl or cable curl. Keep it all eight weeks. Three seconds down on every rep. Count set one for progression. Optional from week 5: rest-pause, explained on Day 3.

Substitutions

THE GYM DOESN'T HAVE	DO THIS INSTEAD
Incline barbell press	Incline machine press, incline dumbbell press, low-to-high cable press, push-up with feet raised
Flat dumbbell press	Machine chest press, barbell bench press, cable chest press, push-up
Front delt press	Machine shoulder press, dumbbell shoulder press, barbell overhead press, pike push-up
Lateral raise	Machine lateral raise, cable lateral raise

THE GYM DOESN'T HAVE	DO THIS INSTEAD
Rear delt punch out	Reverse pec deck, bent-over dumbbell lateral raise, cable face pull, band pull-apart
Triceps drop set	Close-grip bench press into dips, overhead extension into cable pushdown, machine dip
Biceps	Preacher curl, dumbbell curl, cable curl, barbell curl

Day 2: Lower A

Quads lead with a single-leg movement, hamstrings follow with a hip hinge, calves finish with a stretch hold.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Bulgarian split squat, dumbbells	4	8–12 each leg	3-1-1-0	3 min	Rear foot on a bench. Three seconds down to full depth, one-second pause at the bottom, drive up. Deep range of motion is the stimulus. Rest is after both legs.
Romanian deadlift, barbell	4	8–12	3-1-1-0	2–3 min	Hinge at the hips with a slight knee bend. Not a squat. Lower to mid-shin or until the hamstring stretch stops you. Back flat. One-second pause at the stretch, then stand. Hamstrings, glutes and lower back together.
Standing calf raise, interset stretch	3–4	15	3-0-1-30	2 min	Interset stretch: fifteen reps to failure, then on the final rep drop into the deepest stretch at the bottom and hold it for 20 to 30 seconds. It is meant to be intense. Rest two minutes, repeat. Add load when you get fifteen with the hold done.

Substitutions

THE GYM DOESN'T HAVE	DO THIS INSTEAD
Bulgarian split squat	Leg press, goblet squat, machine squat, front squat, walking lunge
Romanian deadlift	Lying leg curl, stiff-leg deadlift with dumbbells, cable pull-through, good morning
Standing calf raise	Seated calf raise, leg press calf raise, single-leg calf raise on a step

Day 3: Upper B (back focus)

Back leads. Pulldown for width, high elbow row for thickness. The same shoulder and arm work as Day 1 closes the session.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Lat pulldown, V-bar or neutral-grip handle	4	8–12	3-1-1-0	2–3 min	Pull to the upper chest with a slight lean back. Drive the elbows down and back, not the hands. Three seconds up to the stretch, one-second pause there, pull hard.
High elbow row, cable or machine	4	8–12	3-1-1-0	2 min	Elbows at or above shoulder height. Rhomboids and mid-back. Squeeze hard at the contraction, stop when the back stops contracting and the traps start.
Front delt press, dumbbell or machine	3	8–12	3-0-1-0	2 min	As Day 1. Elbows tucked, straight up, short of lockout.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Lateral raise, dumbbell	3	8–12	3-0-1-0	90 sec	As Day 1. Straight sets, elbows lead, shoulder height.
Rear delt punch out, cable or machine	3	8–12	3-1-1-0	90 sec	As Day 1. Pause at the stretch, stop before the traps.
Triceps mechanical drop set, close grip to wide grip	3	To failure	3-0-1-0	2 min	Mechanical drop set, as Day 1. Close grip to failure, wide grip to failure, no rest between.
Biceps, one exercise, short rest	6	8–12	3-0-1-0	30–45 sec	Same exercise as Day 1. Optional from week 5, rest-pause: curl to failure, hold the bar and rest 10 to 15 seconds, curl to failure again, three to five more reps. That is one set. Three rest-pause sets replace the six straight sets.

Substitutions

THE GYM DOESN'T HAVE	DO THIS INSTEAD
Lat pulldown	Machine pullover, dumbbell pullover, cable pulldown with any handle, pull-up weighted or assisted
High elbow row	Machine high row, chest-supported dumbbell row, cable high row, T-bar row, inverted row
Shoulders and arms	Same substitutions as Day 1

Day 4: Lower B

Built from the same lower template as Day 2 with the lead movement and the hamstring movement changed, so the two lower days differ. Quads lead with a machine squat, hamstrings follow with a knee-flexion movement, calves finish seated.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Hack squat	4	8–12	3-1-1-0	3 min	Three seconds down to deep range, one-second pause at the bottom, press up. Set the safety stops. Full depth is the point.
Lying leg curl	4	8–12	3-1-1-0	2 min	Three seconds lowering to straight legs, one-second pause at the stretch, curl hard. Hips stay down on the pad. Optional on the last set: interset stretch, hold the straight-leg stretch for 20 to 30 seconds after the final rep.
Seated calf raise, interset stretch	3–4	15	3-0-1-30	2 min	Interset stretch, as Day 2. Fifteen to failure, deep stretch hold on the last rep for 20 to 30 seconds.

Substitutions

THE GYM DOESN'T HAVE	DO THIS INSTEAD
Hack squat	Leg press, machine squat, dumbbell goblet squat, front squat, Bulgarian split squat

THE GYM DOESN'T HAVE	DO THIS INSTEAD
Lying leg curl	Seated leg curl, stiff-leg deadlift with dumbbells, cable pull-through, good morning
Seated calf raise	Leg press calf raise, standing calf raise, single-leg calf raise on a step

Cluster sets, optional from week 5

Cluster set: take the final set of a big lift (incline press, pulldown, row, hack squat) to failure, rack the weight, take one deep breath, three to five seconds, unrack and go to failure again. Four rounds total counts as one cluster set. Use it only on the last set of a big lift, only from week five, and only on a day when you are short of time. It packs a sixty-minute session into forty. It is not for every session and never for the barbell without a spotter or safety bars.

The week

DAY	SESSION
Monday	Upper A, chest focus
Tuesday	Lower A
Wednesday	Rest, walk
Thursday	Upper B, back focus
Friday	Lower B
Saturday	Rest, walk
Sunday	Rest, walk

The rolling alternative, if your days off move around: two on, one off. Upper A, Lower A, rest, Upper B, Lower B, rest, repeat. On the rolling pattern a "week" in the plan means the next four sessions, not seven calendar days, and the eight weeks take about six and a half calendar weeks. Pick one pattern before week one and keep it.

Progression and troubleshooting

Adding load

Weeks one to four, never. Weeks five to eight, only when every set of an exercise hits twelve with one rep in reserve. Then 5 to 10 lb on the big lifts, 2.5 to 5 lb on the small ones, back to eight reps. Microplates or the smallest dumbbell jump the gym allows. If the next dumbbell is a five-pound jump per hand and twelve becomes six, stay at the old load and keep adding reps past twelve for a week, then try the jump again.

A stalled lift

A lift is stalled when the reps do not move for two consecutive sessions at the same load. Hold the load. Add reps where you can, even one rep on one set counts. When the reps move, the load follows. If two weeks pass with no change on the record, drop the load ten percent and climb back up. Most stalls resolve by week two of the climb, and the lift passes its old number on the way through.

A missed session

Slot it in. If you missed Tuesday's Lower A, do it Wednesday and push the rest of the week by a day, or run the rolling pattern for that week. Never double up two sessions in one day. Two missed sessions in a week means the plan is too big for that week. Run Plan B from the compliance page, log it as Plan B, and come back to the full week next Monday.

Poor sleep

A night under six hours, or three bad nights in a row, caps the session. Drop the last set of every exercise and leave two reps in reserve on everything. No sets to failure that day. No drop sets, no rest-pause, no clusters. Log the session as capped so the record explains itself later.

Shortening rest, optional

The rest times in the tables are the rule for all eight weeks. Shorter rest is a skill, not a shortcut. If after week four you want to build density, cut rest on the isolation work by 15 seconds every two weeks and never below 60 seconds on the big lifts. If reps drop, go back to the table.

When to stop

Muscle fatigue is the work. Sharp pain, joint pain, numbness, or pain that is still there the next morning is not. Stop the set. If it is still there after two days, see a professional. This plan is not medical advice.

Cardio and walking

Walking is the default. Twenty to forty minutes most days, including rest days. It costs nothing in recovery and it is the easiest way to keep daily movement up while the lifting does its work. Rest days are walking, stretching or mobility work. Nothing intense.

Hard cardio is optional. If you want it, it goes on non-lifting days or after a lifting session, never before one. After lifting, fifteen to twenty minutes easy on a bike, incline treadmill or any machine where you can hold a conversation. Keep it easy enough that the next day's session is not affected. If leg day suffers, the cardio is too hard or too close.

The compliance page

Plan A, the full week

- Upper A, Lower A, Upper B and Lower B done.
- Every session logged: exercise, load, reps per set, reps left.
- Protein target hit every day. One gram per pound of bodyweight is the default line.
- Weekly weigh-in average recorded.
- Walks done, 20 to 40 minutes most days.

Plan B, the bare minimum

Two sessions, one upper and one lower, counts as a full week when life blows up. Run the next upper and the next lower in the rotation. If in doubt, Upper A and Lower A. Protein is still hit every day. Log it as Plan B. A Plan B week is a kept week. Three Plan B weeks in a row means the four-day plan is too big for this season of your life, and the record will have told you.

Three questions, every night

- Did I train today, or was it a planned rest day?
- Did I hit protein?
- Did I log it?

Yes or no. Nothing else.

The gate

Eighty percent on the three questions over four weeks means the plan is working. Change nothing before week four.

Week 1 checklist

- Bodyweight Monday morning, fasted, after the bathroom.
- Photos front, side, back. Same light, same place, same clothing each time.
- Read the whole of week 1 before day 1.
- Set the four session days in a calendar now, and the walk days.
- Pick the Plan B days now, one upper and one lower, before you need them.

Discipline without integration is just a faster way to run in the wrong direction.

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Written by Stephen Dugger with help from Claude, an AI model. Every rule in this plan is his.